

Purpose

This guide helps safely reclaim disk space on Windows C: drive used by Docker Desktop and WSL (Ubuntu) without breaking your development environment.

Prerequisites

- Windows PowerShell with Administrator rights
 - Docker Desktop installed
 - WSL (Ubuntu-22.04) installed
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Steps to Reclaim Disk Space

Step 1: Stop Docker completely

1. Right-click the **Docker Desktop icon** in the taskbar.
2. Select **Quit Docker Desktop**.
3. Open **PowerShell as Administrator**.
4. Run the command to stop any remaining Docker processes:

```
Get-Process *docker* | Stop-Process -Force
```

Step 2: Shutdown WSL

```
wsl --shutdown
```

This ensures all WSL instances (Ubuntu-22.04 + docker-desktop) are fully stopped.

Step 3: Locate Docker VHDX Disk

```
dir "$env:LOCALAPPDATA\Docker\wsl\disk"
```

Identify the main Docker virtual disk file (usually `docker_data.vhdx`).

Step 4: Shrink Docker Disk

1. Open **PowerShell as Administrator**.
2. Start DiskPart:

```
diskpart
```

3. Run these commands line by line (replace filename if different):

```
select vdisk file="C:\Users\PC\AppData\Local\Docker\wsl\disk\docker_data.vhdx"  
attach vdisk readonly  
compact vdisk  
detach vdisk  
exit
```

This will reclaim unused space inside Docker's virtual disk.

Step 5: Restart Docker

1. Open **Docker Desktop**.
2. Wait until status is **Running**.
3. Run your Docker containers as usual.

Notes

- This process does **not delete containers, images, volumes, or WSL Ubuntu data**.
- Always ensure Docker Desktop is fully quit before shrinking the VHDX.
- Typical space regained: 10–30+ GB depending on usage.

Optional Future Tip

To prevent low disk space issues in the future, periodically run:

```
docker system prune -a --volumes  
wsl --shutdown
```

Then shrink the VHDX if needed, following Steps 4–5.

End of Guide